

WHAT WILL DELHI LOOK LIKE IN 2047? Start at the edges. Presently, the formless sprawl of the National Capital Region notwithstanding, the mental image is still that of a city centre, thinning out into a semi-rural landscape of fields and low-slung villages. The Master Plan for Delhi-2047 inverts this. The city will be decentred. The rim will grow into a gem-studded necklace: a circular band of high-rise urbania along a 75-km orbital expressway that will be, in effect, Delhi's third Ring Road.

The six-laned Urban Extension Road-II will soak in the full weight of urbanity, turning into a wall of homes, offices, markets, warehouses and public buildings that meet all future needs. UER-II forms a half-crescent on the west—connecting Alipur in the north to Mahipalpur in the south, via Bawana, Rohini, Mundka, Narela, Najafgarh, Dwarka. The plan is to develop a 250-metre strip on its either side as a high-density corridor: plots here can have a floor-area ratio (FAR) of 400—meaning a 1,000 square metre plot can hold 4,000 sq. m of built space. With only 40 per cent ground coverage permitted, that translates into buildings of roughly 10 floors.

What this will yield is a new outer city of mixed use patterns: homes next to markets, clinics, schools et al. With everything built around the hum of the highway, the idea is to create shorter journeys, more living near jobs and thus fewer cars forced to traverse a choked city. A single transport authority is proposed, making the Metro, buses and last-mile links work as one system. Vertical and expensive in places, affordable in others: 20 per cent area is set aside for homes smaller than 60 sq. m.

THE COMING DENSITY

By 2047, Delhi is expected to hold 32 million people. It will need 1,600 million gallons of drinking water a day, peak electricity of 25,500 MW, and a system to handle 25,764 tonnes of waste every day—almost double the current load. Solution: treated wastewater, decentralised sewage treatment, neighbourhood-level wet-waste processing, solar panels on large rooftops. Old colonies can be regenerated by up to 1.5 times, but with pooled land, upgraded drains, parking, congestion charges at hubs.

The Yamuna floodplain will be kept free of construction. All the 22 major drains will be intercepted before they empty into the river. Elsewhere, drains are reimagined in their original form: as wetlands, now regenerated with rain gardens, micro-forests, cycling tracks, permeable pavements and 'bioswales'. ■